proactive post-2018 as they were not sure how the government would react, they say. Nor was there any system of reward or incentives for conducting more operations. There was also the danger of casualties, be it of jan militia members, civilians or security forces, coming under intense scrutiny.

On record, however, security personnel deny there was any lull. "From the security perspective, the monsoon months lead to a reduction in operations owing to overflowing streams and the jungles becoming inaccessible," says Sunder Raj P., Inspector General of Police (IGP), Bastar. "In the post-monsoon months, operations pick up and the increase in arrests and encounters are both due to that."

The numbers bear this out. If there were four encounters between the Maoists and the security forces in Bastar in July 2023, and four, two and two, respectively, in August, September and October, the number of encounters rose sharply to 12 in November, and nine in December. A similar trend could be seen in the number of arrests too. If 15 suspected Maoists were arrested in July, the numbers went up to 26, 28 and 27, and 18 in the four months thereafter. The arrests jumped sharply to 59 in December, while surrenders jumped from two in November to 30 in December.

THE CENTRE THINKS MAOISM IS IN RETREAT. NAXAL INCIDENTS HAVE COME DOWN BY 52%, DEATHS BY 70% IN THE PAST 10 YRS

And even as a severe winter stalks the plains, the hot pursuit continues in the forests of Chhattisgarh, as Op Surya Shakti demonstrates. Simultaneously, infrastructure projects, with a focus on roads and communication towers, are also being fast-tracked. Of course, the Maoists' propensity to strike at will remains a worry, especially as they carry away the firearms after killing the security forces with IEDs. But the deepening engagement in Bastar, with sophisticated assault strategies, may well be a crucial turning point in the war on Maoism, pushing it into the final and decisive phase. ■

MAYAWATI

Solo Ambition

By Prashant Srivastava



THE LONE RANGER
Mayawati releasing a new edition of her autobiography on her 68th birthday, Jan. 15

ANI

Ending all speculations, Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) supremo Mayawati on January 15, her birthday, declared that her party will contest the Lok Sabha election alone, dashing the hopes of INDIA or the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance, especially the Congress, which was keen on her joining the Opposition alliance. So much so that the national party had even cancelled its January 12 meeting with the Samajwadi Party (SP) to discuss seat-sharing in Uttar Pradesh, as state Congress leaders were hoping for Mayawati to make an announcement in their favour on her 68th birthday.

But addressing the media in Lucknow, the former UP chief minister claimed the BSP's experience with alliances has not been "beneficial". "We suffer more losses," she said. "Most of the parties want to ally with the BSP. But the BSP will fight the elections alone." Citing the 2007 Vidhan Sabha election, when the BSP won 206 of the 403 assembly seats, Mayawati said it was the combined